

and will have rights only to the Temporary Internet Files and Cookies directory.

This effectively stops many ActiveX controls and malicious scripts that download files to areas such as the Desktop or Startup menu. Besides specific applications, you can even create a sandbox for all generic applications. For example, no application will have rights over the root folder. This is quite an innovative concept; no other firewall employed this concept.

SubSeven Trojan detection: Since we were testing the firewalls using SubSeven 2.2, which is the latest version and doesn't even show up in the processes list, we didn't really expect the firewalls to detect this version. But surprisingly, BlackICE immediately detected the SubSeven 2.2 Trojan

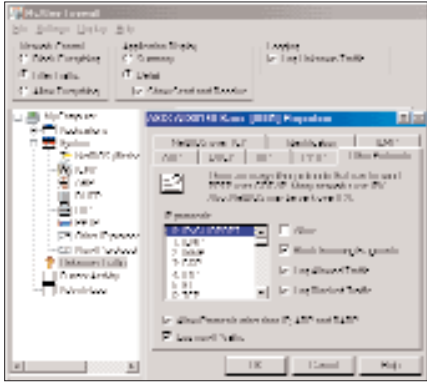


The feature-rich Norton Personal Firewall

when we tried running the SubSeven server and sending it through. None of the firewalls allowed access to the SubSeven Trojan when we started the server with the firewall running.

However, when we made the connection to the SubSeven server first and then started the firewall, quite a few were found wanting. Norton, ZoneAlarm and NeoWatch allowed the SubSeven client to issue commands such as opening the CD-ROM, or hiding the Start menu. Other commands such as packet sniffing didn't work with the first two, though NeoWatch allowed even these commands. This is a major security breach because if a Trojan can start its activities before the start of the firewall then it can bypass many restrictions. Firewalls that were based on creating application-level rules didn't face a problem because these were able to detect that some application was trying to connect to the Internet.

None of the firewalls we tested were good in all respects. Norton Personal Firewall, with support for blocking ActiveX and Java applets, could have been a good all-round performer but for its failure in the SubSeven Trojan test. ZoneAlarm Pro and BlackICE Defender performed well,



Block a range of protocols with McAfee

but they lacked protection against malicious Web sites. Interestingly, if you can get eSafe Desktop to work properly and tweak its settings, you might get the best protection including protection against Trojans and malicious sites. With its concept of sandboxes, you can virtually guard all your main system files. You can also manually specify ports that should be blocked for both inbound and outbound connections. The problem is that we faced a lot of difficulties in getting eSafe to work. Configuring this software is also not that simple and requires thorough knowledge of each application and port, so this is not something

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